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FIELD GUIDE · NO. 01
WINTER 2026 · FREE FOR THERAPISTS

THE 2027 ISSUE

The Full-Caseload *Plan*

Turn website visitors into booked clients before January. A calm, four-week plan for therapists, counselors and psychologists.



The leaks
Why visitors leave without booking

Fees, said well
Private pay without scaring people off

Found by AI
Google, ChatGPT and the short list

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START HERE

Most therapy websites don't have a traffic problem. They have a booking problem.

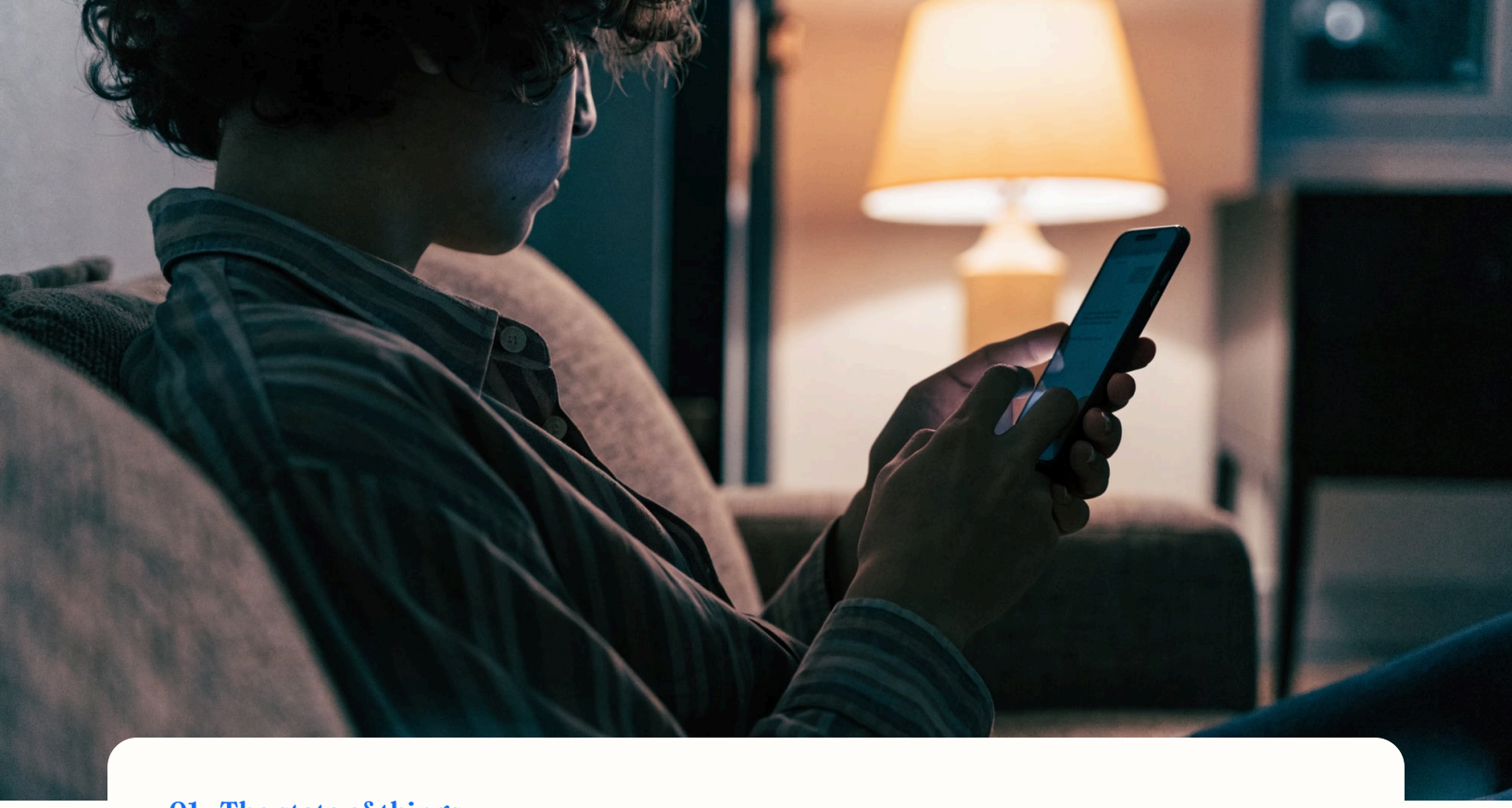
People land, look around, feel unsure, and leave without reaching out. Nobody tells you, so it's easy to blame the market, the directories, or yourself.

This guide is a plan to fix that before the new-year rush many practices see in January. You won't need new software or a marketing degree. Each section ends with a few concrete fixes, and the last one turns them into four weeks of work.

No hype. Nobody can promise you a full caseload. We can remove the reasons people leave.

Ethics first. Everything here respects your board's rules on testimonials and privacy.

Small steps. About an hour a week. Block it like a session.



01 · The state of things

Why inquiries feel slower in 2026

If finding new clients feels harder this year, you're far from alone. And most of it isn't about you.

Therapists describe the same pattern: fewer contacts, more questions about fees, and people taking longer to commit. Directory referrals that once felt steady have thinned out, while more clients now shortlist two or three names through Google and AI tools before they reach out to anyone.

Insurance is in flux too. More therapists are leaving panels over low reimbursement, and the final 2027 Medicare fee schedule, due in November, is proposed to trim the main conversion factor by about 1.7%. One piece of good news: Medicare telehealth flexibilities run through December 31, 2027.

Here's the part you control. Clients check you out quietly before they ever call. Your website isn't a brochure anymore. It's where the decision happens.

48%

of clinicians name marketing and client acquisition as their most stressful task

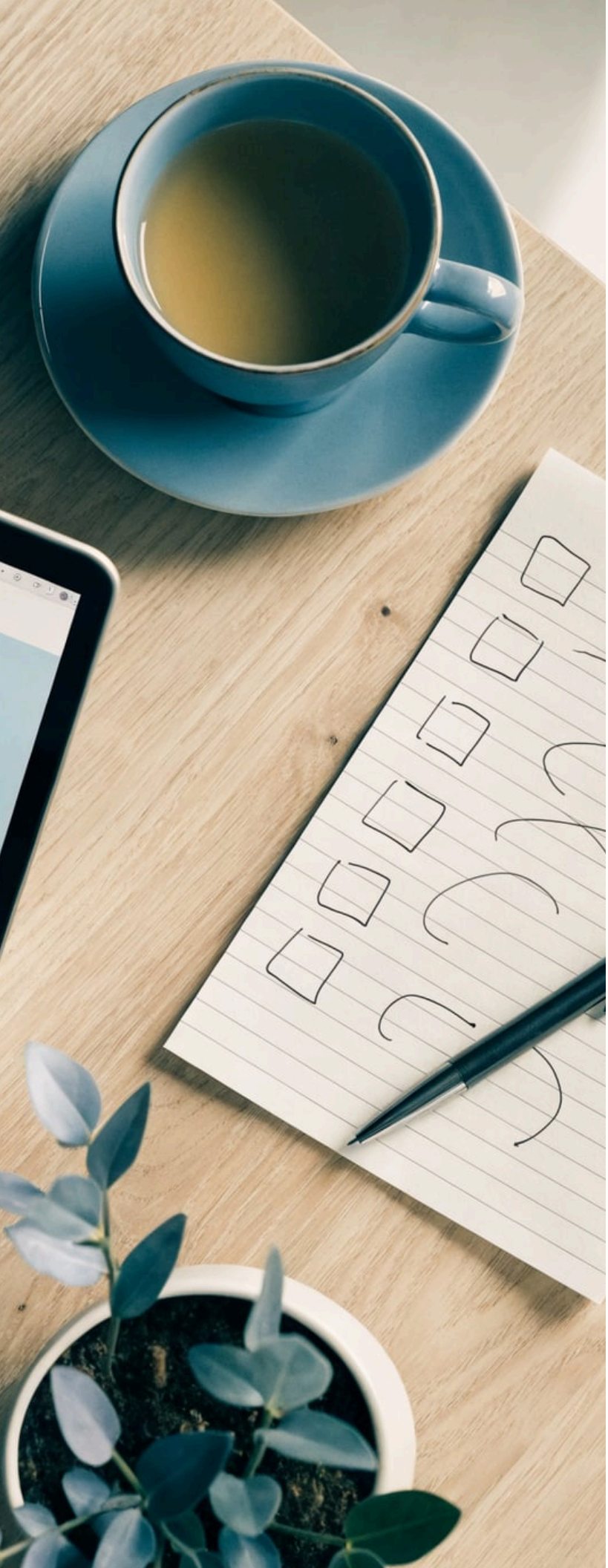
42%

report burnout in 2026, up from 29% in 2023

~1.7%

proposed cut to Medicare's main 2027 conversion factor

Sources: SimplePractice and Heard, 2026 Clinician Well-Being Study; CMS CY 2027 Physician Fee Schedule proposed rule.



02 · THE LEAKS

Where visitors drop off

Open your site on your phone. Pretend you're a stressed person looking for help at 11pm. Every unchecked box is a reason someone might leave.

IN THE FIRST FIVE SECONDS

- [ ] The top says who you help, with what, in everyday words
- [ ] It says where you see clients: city, state, telehealth
- [ ] One clear button, like "Book a free 15-minute call"
- [ ] Loads fast on a phone, no pop-ups in the way

WHEN THEY START READING

- [ ] The copy talks about their struggles, not your résumé
- [ ] Each specialty has its own page
- [ ] A real, current photo of you
- [ ] You describe what a first session is like

WHEN THEY GET SERIOUS

- [ ] Fees, insurance and out-of-network details are clear
- [ ] You say whether you're taking new clients
- [ ] The form sends, the phone works, the link isn't broken

THE ONE-MINUTE TEST

Ask a friend who isn't a therapist to find your fee, your availability and how to book. Time it. Over a minute, and a nervous client probably won't bother.

03 · FEES, SAID WELL

Talking about money without scaring people off

Hiding your fee rarely helps. People assume the worst, or leave to find someone who's upfront.

A GOOD FEES PAGE INCLUDES

- [ ] Your session fee and session length
- [ ] Whether you offer a sliding scale, and how to ask
- [ ] Which insurance you take, or a plain "I'm out-of-network"
- [ ] How superbills work, in two or three sentences
- [ ] Payment methods, including HSA and FSA cards
- [ ] Your cancellation policy
- [ ] A note on the Good Faith Estimate US self-pay clients are entitled to

WORDS THAT HELP

"Investment" sounds salesy to a lot of clients. "Fee" is fine.

Say what's included: "50-minute session, in person or by video."

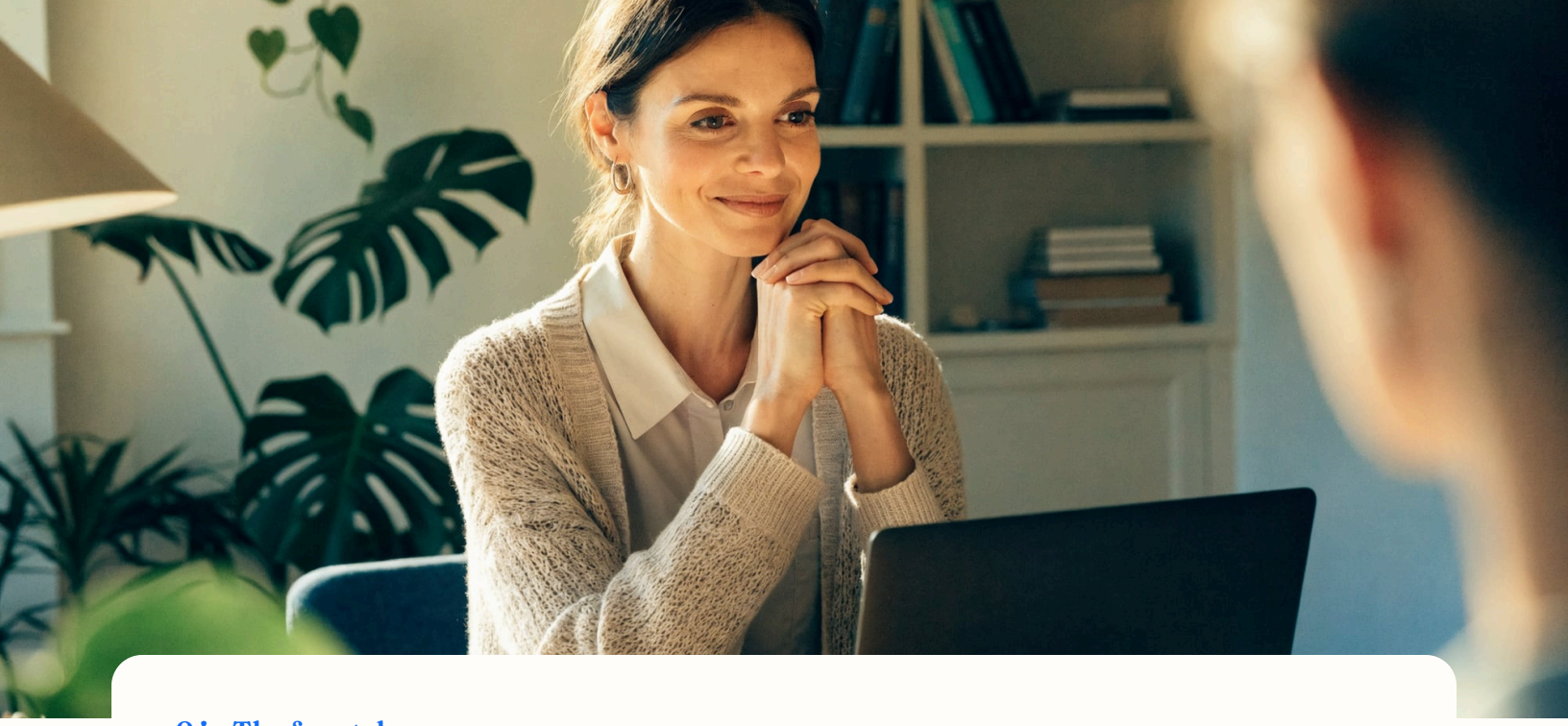
Limited sliding-scale spots? Say so plainly instead of hiding the option.

> *A clear, calm fees page builds more trust than any "call to discuss rates."*

COPY THIS · OUT-OF-NETWORK WORDING

I'm an out-of-network provider. You pay at each session, and I give you a monthly superbill to send to your insurance. Many plans reimburse part of the cost. Before we start, call the number on your card and ask: "Do I have out-of-network mental health benefits? What's my deductible, and what percentage do you reimburse?"

Leaving insurance in 2027? Add one factual line about why you work this way, for example that no diagnosis is required to start, or that sessions aren't limited by an insurer. Keep it calm, not defensive.



04 · The front door

Make booking the easy part

Reaching out takes courage. Voicemail, a broken form or a week of silence and many people just give up.

MORE THAN ONE WAY IN

- [ ] Self-booking link for a free 15-minute consult
- [ ] A short form: name, email, phone, best time, one optional box
- [ ] A voicemail greeting that says when you'll call back

REPLY FAST, EVEN IN SESSION ALL DAY

- [ ] Auto-reply with timing and crisis resources
- [ ] Two short windows a day for calls and messages
- [ ] Reply within one business day, and say so

MAKE THE CONSULT CALL COUNT

- [ ] Ask what brings them in, what they hope will change, and any limits
- [ ] Cover fees and availability on the call
- [ ] Not a fit? Refer on warmly. It's remembered.
- [ ] Book the first session before you hang up

SHORTEN THE WAIT

Next opening three weeks out? Say so, and offer a waitlist with a promise to check in. A clear wait beats an unclear one.

05 · GET FOUND

On Google and AI tools

More clients start by asking Google or ChatGPT for names. Those tools build answers from the public web, so the job is simple: make what the web says about you clear, current and consistent.

The five-minute test

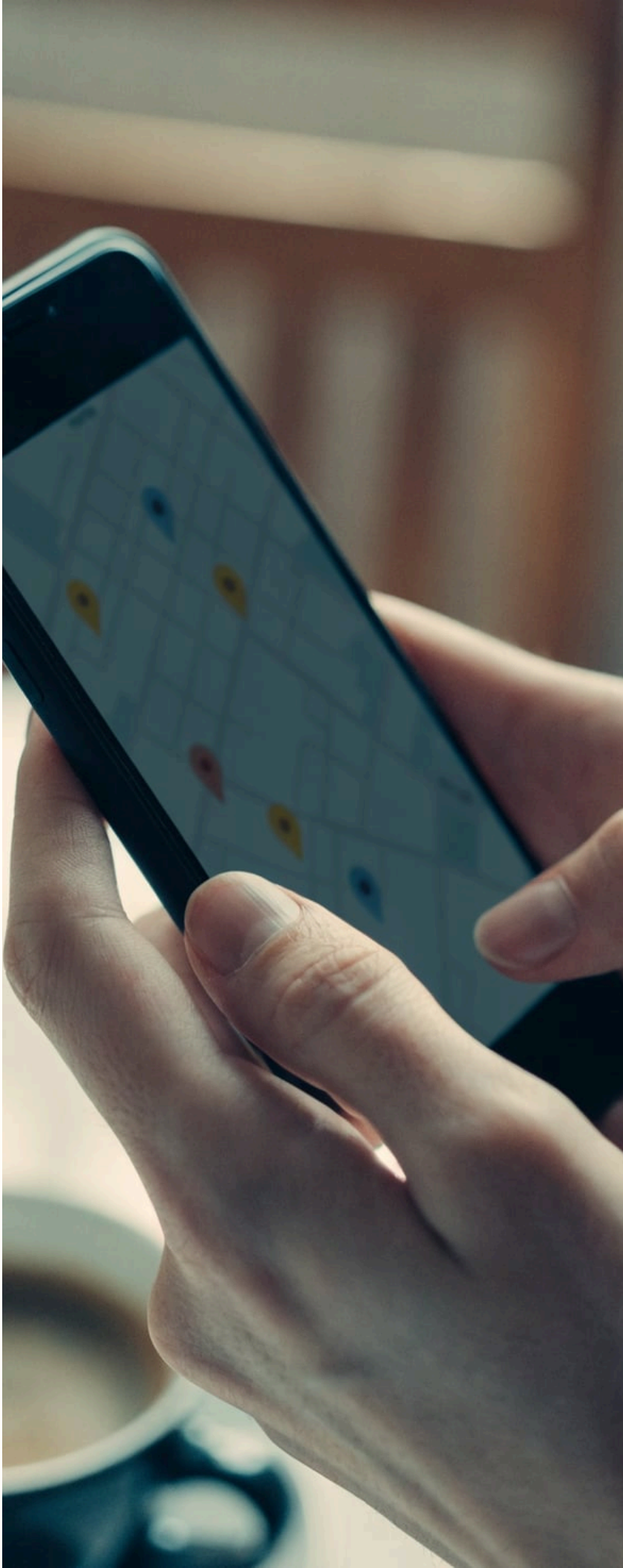
In a private window, ask ChatGPT, Gemini and Google:

1. Find me a therapist in [city] who helps with [specialty].
2. What do you know about [your name], [license], in [city]?

If the second draws a blank, start below.

- [ ] Complete your Google Business Profile
- [ ] Set up Bing Places and Apple Business Connect
- [ ] Identical name, address and phone everywhere
- [ ] One sentence on who you help, used in every listing
- [ ] Site open to AI crawlers, linked to Search Console

Skip: llms.txt files, bought mentions, dozens of AI-written posts, and anyone guaranteeing a spot in ChatGPT.



06 · TRUST WITHOUT TESTIMONIALS

Reviews, the ethical way

In most businesses, reviews do the trust-building. In yours, ethics codes and HIPAA change the rules.

The ACA, APA, NASW and AAMFT codes all restrict soliciting testimonials, and HIPAA limits using client information in marketing. Check your own board's exact wording, since it varies.

GENERALLY OK	GENERALLY NOT OK
A claimed Google profile clients can review on their own	Asking current clients for reviews, in any form
A plain link to your Google profile, with no request	Review cards, automated review emails or incentives
Endorsements from colleagues who know your work	Writing reviews yourself, or having friends post them
Replies that don't confirm anyone is a client	Replies that confirm a reviewer is or was your client

A SAFE REPLY TO ANY REVIEW

"Thank you for sharing this. Because of privacy laws, we can't discuss anyone's care online. If you'd like to talk, please contact our office directly."

TRUST BUILDERS THAT ARE ALWAYS FINE

- [ ] A warm About page in your own voice
- [ ] Credentials and trainings, with links
- [ ] A short video on what a first session is like
- [ ] Talks, podcasts or articles you've written
- [ ] Clear privacy, cancellation and crisis policies

Outside the US, rules can be stricter. In Australia, for example, AHPRA restricts testimonials for registered health practitioners.



07 · The plan

Your four-week, pre-January plan

About an hour a week. Start any week in November or December and you're done before New Year's.

WEEK 1

See it like a client

- [ ] Phone walkthrough and the friend test
- [ ] Run the five-minute Google and AI test
- [ ] Write your one-sentence description

WEEK 2

Fix the first impression

- [ ] That sentence and one booking button up top
- [ ] Update your photo and About page
- [ ] Publish or refresh your fees page

WEEK 3

Fix the front door

- [ ] Free consult booking link, tested end to end
- [ ] Auto-reply on your form and email
- [ ] Google, Bing and Apple listings claimed

WEEK 4

Get ready to measure

- [ ] Add "ChatGPT or another AI tool" to intake
- [ ] Name, address and phone match everywhere
- [ ] Monthly reminder to rerun the tests

None of this guarantees a full caseload. It removes the most common reasons people leave without reaching out, and that's the part you control.

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A LAST WORD

You didn't get into this work to become a marketer.

The good news: what turns a visitor into a client is close to what makes a good first session. Clarity, warmth, and no surprises.

Want a second pair of eyes? Book a free 30-minute call. We'll walk through your site together and point out the biggest leaks. No pitch deck, no pressure.

Book your free call · wwisermind.com

Sources

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The Private Practice Pro: Biggest private practice challenges in 2026

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CMS: CY 2027 Physician Fee Schedule proposed rule

Perspective AI: Reducing therapy no-shows at intake

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Koppla Marketing: Therapy websites and AI search

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